3. The Mandate of Heaven and Rule over ‘All Under Heaven’

A distinctive Chinese identity began to emerge among the communities settled in the middle reaches of the great rivers, the Huang He (Yellow River) and the Yangzi Jiang (Yangzi river), which could be said to constitute the Chinese heartland, the original location of the Middle Kingdom. The Shang dynasty ruled in the Middle Kingdom from about 1500 BCE to 1046 BCE . It succeeded the ancient Xia dynasty, about which little is known, but this dynastic change is important because this marks the beginning of the notion that earthly rule by a king is legitimized by divine sanction. The year 1500 was marked by a rare conjunction of planets that occurred only once in 516 years and was regarded as a sign of dynastic change. This became known as the Mandate of Heaven during the succeeding Zhou dynasty. The king was cast in the role of intermediary between the people and heaven and was responsible for their well-being and peaceful lives. The mandate covered the ‘Middle Kingdom’, as the Chinese conceived of their position in the world known to them during different periods of history. [1]

As we have seen, the Chinese empire grew over time from its rule over the river valleys of central China to cover a much larger expanse. And this world represented ‘Tianxia’, or ‘All Under Heaven’. In discharging the Mandate of Heaven, the ruler needed to perform various rituals to propitiate Heaven. He had to perform divination to understand what various heavenly signs may mean. This was also a period when ancestor worship began to crystallize as a tradition. Ancestors were important as additional channels of intercession for mankind with Heaven. As pointed out in Chapter 1, the unique form of Chinese writing in the form of ideograms emerged during the Shang period as part of the divination rituals, which involved the use of tortoise shells and animal bones.